

Weekly Reflection Journal Rubric

How your daily reflection journal is graded

OVERVIEW

Your reflection journal is a short daily check-in at the end of class. It takes about five minutes, Monday through Friday. You answer three questions about your learning. There are no wrong answers. Your journal is graded with five levels. Each level shows how clearly you can explain your own learning, not whether your answer matches a key.

Question 1: What did you learn today?

Skill: I am able to name a specific thing I learned today and describe it clearly.

Missing 0%

Missing: There is no attempt to name something learned today.

Emerging 55%

Emerging: There is an attempt to name something learned today

- BUT -

the response is blank, off topic, or copies the question without adding an idea

- OR -

the response names a topic without any description of what was learned about it.

Approaching 65%

Approaching: There is a partial attempt to name something learned today

-BECAUSE-

the response names a real topic or idea from class

-BUT-

the description stays general and could apply to any day or any class

-OR-

the response repeats the class activity without saying what the student now understands.

For example:

- "We learned about friction."
- "I learned cells today."
- "We did the lab with the ramps."

Developing 85%

Developing: There is a solid attempt to name something learned today

-BECAUSE-

the response names a specific idea or concept from today's class

-AND-

the response describes the idea in the student's own words

-BUT-

the description is short, missing a detail, or slightly unclear

-OR-

the response names a specific idea but explains it with the exact words of the teacher or the textbook.

For example:

- "I learned that friction slows objects down and it depends on the surface."
- "I learned that cells have membranes that control what goes in and out."
- "I learned that the ramp angle changes how fast the cart moves."

Refining 100%

Refining: There is a strong attempt to name something learned today

-BECAUSE-

the response names a specific idea or concept from today's class

-AND-

the response describes the idea in the student's own words with a detail or example

-AND-

the description is clear enough that someone who was not in class could understand what was learned.

For example:

- "I learned that friction is a force that opposes motion, like when my shoe grips the gym floor and keeps me from sliding."
- "I learned that the cell membrane is selective, so it lets water in but blocks some chemicals, which explains why the potato slice changed size in the salt water."
- "I learned that a steeper ramp gives the cart more acceleration because gravity pulls it along the slope more strongly."

Question 2: How did you learn it?

Skill: I am able to explain the process, activity, or strategy that helped me learn.

Missing 0%

Missing: There is no attempt to explain how the learning happened.

Emerging 55%

Emerging: There is an attempt to explain how the learning happened

- BUT -

the response only restates the answer to question one without naming how it was learned

- OR -

the response is blank, off topic, or copies the question.

Approaching 65%

Approaching: There is a partial attempt to explain how the learning happened

-BECAUSE-

the response mentions a class activity, such as a lab, discussion, video, or reading

-BUT-

the response does not say how that activity helped the idea make sense

-OR-

the response gives only a vague process word like "we studied" or "I paid attention" with no detail.

For example:

- "We learned it in the lab."
- "We watched a video and took notes."
- "I studied and listened in class."

Developing 85%

Developing: There is a solid attempt to explain how the learning happened

-BECAUSE-

the response names a specific activity or strategy used in class

-AND-

the response connects that activity to how the idea became clear

-BUT-

the connection is short, missing a step, or stays on the surface.

For example:

- "We rolled the cart down ramps at different angles, and seeing the times get shorter showed me why the steeper ramp made it faster."
- "The diagram in our notes helped because I could see the membrane as a barrier instead of just reading the word."
- "Arguing about the answer in our group made me realize I had the direction of friction backwards."

Refining 100%

Refining: There is a strong attempt to explain how the learning happened

-BECAUSE-

the response names a specific activity or strategy used in class

-AND-

the response connects that activity to how the idea became clear

-AND-

the response reflects on why that way of learning worked, or names a moment when the idea clicked.

For example:

- "Testing the ramps myself worked better than the video, because when I changed only the angle and the cart got faster every time, I could see the cause and effect myself."
- "The potato lab made it click for me. When the slice shrank in salt water, I finally understood the membrane moving water, not just blocking it."
- "Explaining my answer out loud to my partner showed me the gap in my reasoning, and fixing it is what made the concept stick."

Question 3: What is still unclear, or what are you curious about?

Skill: I am able to name something still unclear or a curiosity, and explain why it matters or what I have tried.

Missing 0%

Missing: There is no attempt to name something unclear or a curiosity.

Emerging 55%

Emerging: There is an attempt to name something unclear or a curiosity

- BUT -

the response is blank, off topic, or copies the question

- OR -

the response says "nothing" or "I don't know" without adding any idea.

Approaching 65%

Approaching: There is a partial attempt to name something unclear or a curiosity

-BECAUSE-

the response names a real question or confusing point

-BUT-

the response does not say why it matters or what the student has tried

-OR-

the question is so general it could be asked in any class on any day.

For example:

- "I'm confused about friction."
- "Why do cells need membranes?"
- "I don't get the ramp math."

Developing 85%

Developing: There is a solid attempt to name something unclear or a curiosity

-BECAUSE-

the response names a specific question, confusion, or curiosity tied to today's class

-AND-

the response says why it matters or what the student has already tried

-BUT-

the explanation of why it matters is short, missing a step, or slightly off from the main idea.

For example:

- "I'm still unsure how friction works on ice, because we only tested rough surfaces, and I tried thinking about my driveway in winter but I'm not sure it fits."
- "I'm curious why the salt water made the potato shrink instead of grow, and I reread the notes but the word 'selective' is still fuzzy."
- "I don't fully get why the steepest ramp gave the fastest time. I tried graphing it but my line does not look like the other groups' lines."

Refining 100%

Refining: There is a strong attempt to name something unclear or a curiosity

-BECAUSE-

the response names a specific question, confusion, or curiosity tied to today's class

-AND-

the response explains why it matters for understanding the bigger idea

-AND-

the response shows what the student has already tried and proposes a next step, a connection to another idea, or a way to test it.

For example:

- "I'm still unsure how friction works on ice, because our data only covered rough surfaces, and I want to retest with a smooth board and compare, since friction changing with the surface is the main idea of the unit."
- "I'm curious if the membrane would still shrink the potato in sugar water the same way, and I checked two sources that disagreed, so my next step is to ask which solute concentration they used."
- "I don't fully see why mass did not change the cart's acceleration, because heavier feels like it should fall faster. I want to run the ramp test with a loaded cart to test my own prediction."

Question 4: Completion

Skill: I am able to complete my journal every in-school day, and note my absences.

Missing 0%

Missing: There is no genuine attempt to complete the journal.

-OR-

the whole week is blank, placeholder text, or copied questions with no real answers.

Emerging 55%

Emerging: There is an attempt to complete the journal

-BUT-

the week is under 60% complete, meaning less than three of five days hold genuine answers

-OR-

only one or two days have real answers and the rest are blank or placeholders.

-OR-

every answer is so thin it barely counts, but at least one day shows a genuine try.

Note: any genuine attempt, even on a single day, earns at least this tier. Missing days still count against you here.

Approaching 65%

Approaching: There is a partial attempt to complete the journal

-BECAUSE-

the week is 60 to 79% complete, meaning about three of five days hold genuine answers, or two full days plus partial answers that add up

-BUT-

one or two in-school days are missing or only partly answered

-OR-

an absence is noted for a missing day but the note has no explanation, so the day cannot be excused.

For example:

- "3 of 5 days done, Tuesday and Thursday blank"
- "2 of 5 days done, 1 day half answered, 2 days blank"
- "4 of 5 days done, Friday absence noted with no explanation"

Developing 85%

Developing: There is a solid attempt to complete the journal

-BECAUSE-

the week is 80 to 99% complete, meaning at least four of five days hold genuine answers

-AND-

any missing day is either answered in part or has an absence note with a brief explanation, which excuses that day

-BUT-

one in-school day is missing or only partly answered, so the week is not fully complete.

For example:

- "4 of 5 days complete, no absences"
- "5 of 5 days, one day with only 2 of 3 questions answered"
- "3 of 5 days complete, 1 absence noted and explained, 1 day blank"

Refining 100%

Refining: There is a strong attempt to complete the journal

-BECAUSE-

every in-school day holds genuine answers to all three questions, making the week 100% complete

-OR-

every missed day is excused: the absence note for that day is filled in with a brief explanation, and excused days do not count against the week.

If you are absent, fill in the absence note for that day with a few words about why, like "out sick" or "family trip." You do not need to share private details. The day is excused and removed from the count.

For example:

- "5 of 5 days, all three questions answered each day"
- "4 of 5 days complete, Friday absence noted and explained"
- "3 of 5 days complete, 2 absences noted and explained"

Tier ladder

Missing · 0%

Nothing was submitted.

Emerging · 55%

Something was submitted, but the skill is just starting.

Approaching · 65%

The skill is partly there, with important pieces missing.

Developing · 85%

The skill is mostly there, with a small gap left.

Refining · 100%

The skill is clearly there, and practice keeps it strong.